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Volume XXXV Number 5; For the week
Jan 26-Feb 1, 2010, released on January 25

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• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301. Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines), (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; e-mail: ircare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Connaught House, P-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Park, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825498; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia, Kolkata • 6-3-8857/8, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 • 39/1045, Karakatt Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 • 2/C, 'Suryakant Bldg', 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchsheel, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 • Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press India Ltd., 18-15 Millstone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007. (Haryana); A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimal Nagar, district Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and at Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra). Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001. • INDIA TODAY does not take the responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

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From the editor-in-chief

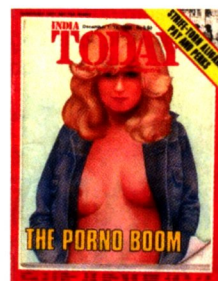
There is no escaping the Indian obsession with fair skin. Television and print advertisements are dominated by fairness creams and it's a prime requirement in most matrimonial columns. We Indians are subject to complex bigotries within our own cultures. In the subcontinent, light skin has historically been linked to high caste, wealth and sophistication while dark skin gets equated with the lower strata of society. Others link it to our colonial past but the fact remains that white skin is eminently desirable: in more ways than one. Just check out the personal columns in the country's leading newspapers. Every day, ads appear offering massage services by 'white girls', some are even more sexually explicit about the services on offer.

The police have recently unearthed several call girl rackets involving white-skinned girls in the capital as well as other cities like Mumbai. The general belief was that these are isolated cases but INDIA TODAY's investigation into the new white sex trade made some startling discoveries. The call girls are literally that since they all operate on mobile phones and are part of a highly sophisticated network operating across India and with global links. The huge influx of foreign prostitutes into India is also a reflection of shifts in the global economy. They all come from the former Soviet republics where high unemployment and weak economies lead them into selling their bodies in countries like India where affluence is rising and affordability of foreign call girls is on the rise. The girls arrive in India often with the approval of their parents/boyfriends who need to pay off financial debts back in their own country.

It's a sort of reverse outsourcing of the world's oldest profession. Some treat it as just another job. They charge 40 per cent more than Indian prostitutes and are changing the rules of the game, feeding on the Indian fascination with white skin, the permissiveness that comes with affluent lifestyles and the increasing openness with which the classified sections of prominent newspapers as well as websites allow them to sell their sexual favours.

Principal Correspondent Mihir Srivastava has been investigating the racket for some months now, posing as a businessman and potential client. He discovered that currently there are over 6,000 foreign women prostitutes in India, having come in on tourist visas. The better looking girls earn close to half a lakh a day! Their services could range from having sex with the client to playing hostess at a party dressed in a short skirt, high-heeled boots, and very little else. They operate through a complex web of agents back home, middle-aged women from the same countries who are referred to as 'aunties' while the Indian pimps are now called 'agents'.

For our cover story, we had all the details but lacked visual confirmation in the form of photographs. We then undertook a spycam operation by Srivastava and Photo Editor Bandeep Singh which shows how easily available the women are. All that is required is a mobile phone, ready cash and a taste for the erotic and exotic, which means foreign and white. However, this is an unwelcome form of globalisation because crime, exploitation and sleaze inevitably follow prostitution.



OUR DECEMBER
1978 COVER

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)